

Goalkeeper Pregame Neural Warm-Up

6–8 minutes · Soccer · Field Hockey · Lacrosse · Ice Hockey · Water Polo · Handball

"Stretching gets you loose. Neural warm-ups get you sharp." — Dr. Shah

Goalkeeping is the most visually demanding role in any sport — the fastest reaction windows, the widest peripheral demand, the highest consequence per visual error. The drills below build the **quiet-eye on the shooter's last pre-release tell** — the single most research-validated GK fixation skill across codes.

1

Breathing Reset (Eyes Open)

30–60 sec

Why: Calms the nervous system and sharpens visual focus before the first whistle, faceoff, or serve.

How

- Soft gaze toward a far target
- Inhale through the nose for **4 seconds**
- Exhale through the mouth for **8 seconds**
- Repeat **4 cycles**
- Stand tall, slight knee bend, shoulders relaxed, jaw loose
- Eyes stay open the whole time

Coaching cue

"Calm system. Alert vision. You're not getting sleepy — you're turning the system ON."

2

Monocular Eye Stretches

30–45 sec

Why: Isolates each eye, reduces dominance issues, exposes weak eye control before it shows up in play.

How

- Cover one eye
- With the open eye, trace an **"English flag" pattern**:
 - Up-left → up-right
 - Middle-left → middle-right
 - Down-left → down-right
- Hit all corners once, then switch eyes

Coaching cue

"Smooth control, no rushing."

If one eye feels jumpy, you just found a leak.

3

Horizontal Saccades

30–45 sec

Why: Goal-mouth scan + side-to-side tracking; recovery position awareness across the crease or goal line.

How

- Thumbs at shoulder width, eye level
- Head still, jaw relaxed
- Snap eyes left ↔ right between thumbs
- 20–30 reps
- Notice the next thumb in peripheral vision before jumping

Coaching cue

"Eyes snap. Face stays quiet."

■ If the jaw or head moves → motor overflow → nervous system is leaking energy.

4

Vertical Saccades

30–45 sec

Why: High shot to low shot vertical reads; aerial tracking on crosses, lobs, high releases, and rebounds.

How

- One thumb high, one thumb low
- Head still
- Snap eyes up ↓ down between thumbs
- 20–30 reps

Coaching cue

"Eyes move fast. Head stays quiet."

5

VOR — Side to Side

45–60 sec

Why: Vision stability through dive recovery, lateral pushes on the goal line, and post-to-post movement.

How

- Thumb at arm's length
- Lock eyes on thumb
- Rotate head side to side
- Thumb must stay **clear, not blurry**
- 10 controlled reps

Coaching cue

"Eyes stay locked. Body moves underneath."

6

VOR — Up and Down

30–45 sec

Why: Eye stability through coming off the line, claiming aerials, rising for a save, or driving out for a 1v1.

How

- Thumb at arm's length
- Lock eyes on thumb
- Move head up ↓ down
- Keep thumb clear the entire time
- 10 controlled reps

Coaching cue

"Head moves. Eyes hold."

7

Near–Far Focus (Thumb Push-Ups)

45–60 sec

Why: Near-net to far-arc depth reads — six-yard box to penalty spot, crease to top of the circle, post to penalty area.

How

- Thumb at arm's length
- Slowly bring thumb toward nose until it doubles
- Push back out until it's single again
- **8–10 controlled reps**
- Progress: look past thumb → let thumb double; look in front of thumb → let background double

Coaching cue

"Clear → double → clear. Own the switch."

8

Peripheral Hand Motion (Partner)

45–60 sec

Why: Attacker runs, off-ball cuts, and back-post / back-side movement during crosses and set plays.

How

- Lock eyes on partner's nose — soften gaze
- Partner moves **both hands** randomly in your peripheral field
- Athlete copies/mirrors the hand pattern using **peripheral vision only**
- Eyes stay on the nose the entire time
- Progress to **asymmetric motion** (one hand fast, one slow)
- 10 random patterns

Coaching cue

"Don't look at it. Detect it."

9

Pre-Release Tell Quiet-Eye + 1v1 Read — Sport-Specific Finisher

60–90 sec

Why: Plant-foot quiet-eye is the strongest published predictor of shot-direction reading in soccer GK research. The same principle — locking onto the shooter's last pre-release cue — predicts save success across sports. Build the habit pre-game so it's automatic when the breakaway / odd-man rush / set piece comes.

How

- Coach simulates a 1v1 approach with varied release angles
- GK **anchors quiet-eye on the pre-release tell** (plant foot, stick angle, lead arm) while keeping the **ball / puck in peripheral vision** — you are *noticing both*, not choosing between them. You don't stop tracking the ball; you add a body-cue anchor on top of it.
- GK calls direction before contact (e.g. *NEAR / FAR / CHIP · HIGH / LOW · BLOCKER / STICK*)
- **15 reps** across approaches
- Progress: add a commit-or-hold call (*COMMIT / SPREAD / HOLD*)

Pre-release tell by sport

- **Soccer / Futsal:** plant-foot direction

- **Field hockey / Lacrosse:** stick angle and backswing height at the top of the load
- **Ice hockey:** blade angle, lead shoulder, and hip rotation at the point of release
- **Water polo:** lead arm orientation and body lean before the wind-up
- **Handball:** hip and plant-foot rotation before arm acceleration

Coaching cue

"The tell tells you everything. Listen to it."

10

Quiet-Eye Reset

30–45 sec

Why: Settles pre-game chaos. Improves decision-making and timing accuracy.

How

- Pick a small spot — the shooter's pre-release tell, or the strike point on the ball/puck at contact
- Soft focus, nasal breathing
- 4-sec inhale / 6–8-sec exhale × 5 breaths

Coaching cue

"Calm eyes. Calm brain. Elite performance."

Coach's note

The pre-release tell — plant foot in soccer, stick angle in hockey and lacrosse, lead arm and body lean in water polo, hip rotation in handball — is the strongest predictor of shot direction at the elite level. The drill **does not replace ball/puck tracking**; it **layers a body-cue anchor on top of it**. The ball stays in peripheral awareness while the tell carries the read. Every GK warm-up should reinforce this dual fixation habit. The value compounds every game.

When to Use

- Before team warm-ups
- Right before kickoff, first whistle, or faceoff
- At halftime or between periods if focus drops
- Before high-pressure moments (penalties, shootouts, set pieces, key possessions)

Key Reminder

You're not trying to get tired. You're training your **eyes, brain, and nervous system** to be ready before the game starts.

If your system isn't ready — the game feels fast.

If it is? The game slows down.

Elite Athlete Next Step

If you want to actually measure and train this system — not guess — that's where we take you through **SEE → PROCESS → ACT** testing plus a **12-week program** built for your sport. Weekly virtual visits + weekly virtual testing.

Don't just warm up your body.

Warm up how you see the game.

Aakash Shah, O.D., FOVDRA

Founder, Shah Neurovision Sports Training